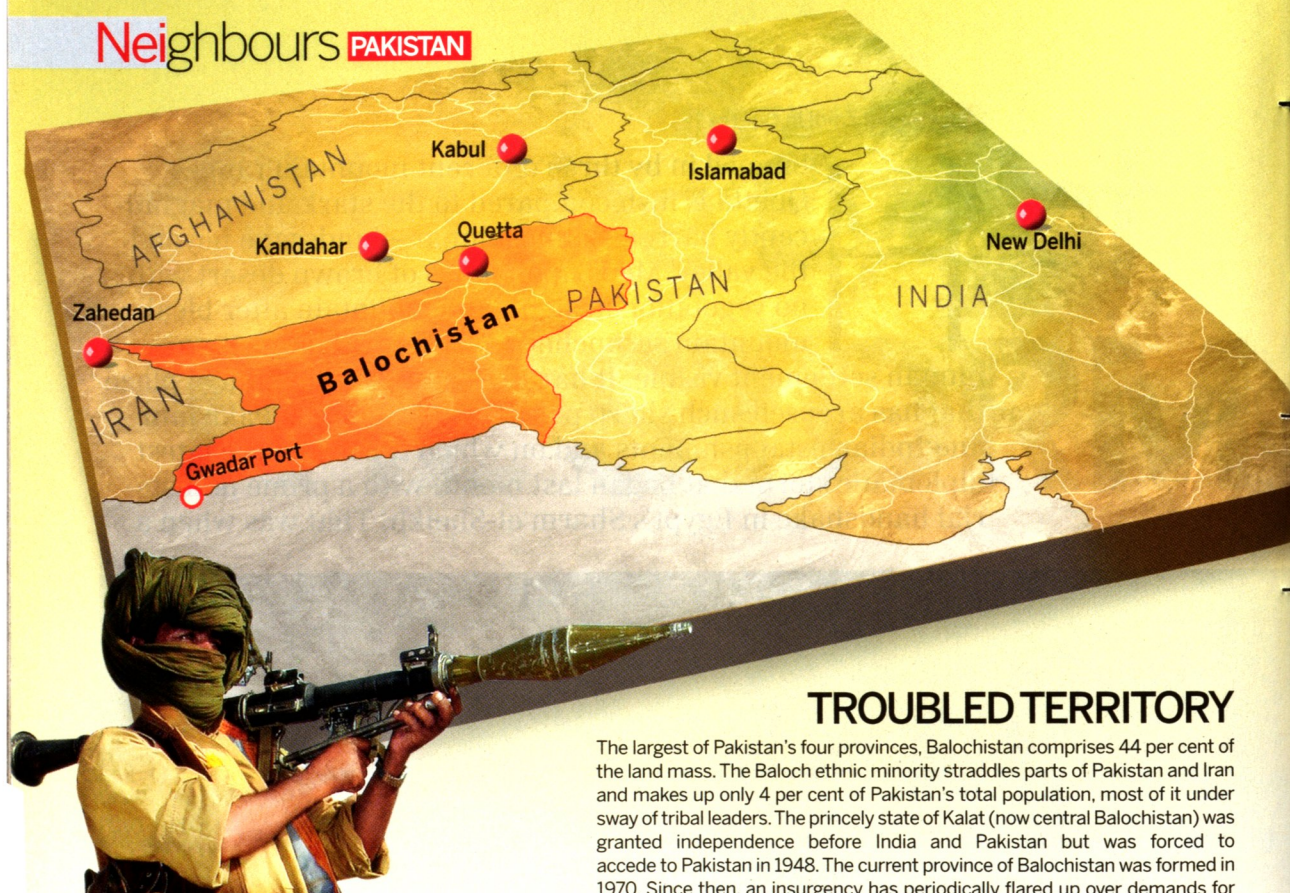


Neighbours **PAKISTAN**



Turbulent Decades

1948

Pakistan's military threat forces accession of princely state of Kalat to Pakistan

1974

The first major Baloch revolt. Ruthlessly crushed by Pakistan and Iran.

2005

The Pakistan Army begins an operation in the Marri tribal area against the rebels

2006

Chief of Bugti tribe Nawab Akbar Khan Bugti is killed

2009

Balochistan finds mention in the joint Indo-Pak statement at Sharm el-Sheikh

TROUBLED TERRITORY

The largest of Pakistan's four provinces, Balochistan comprises 44 per cent of the land mass. The Baloch ethnic minority straddles parts of Pakistan and Iran and makes up only 4 per cent of Pakistan's total population, most of it under sway of tribal leaders. The princely state of Kalat (now central Balochistan) was granted independence before India and Pakistan but was forced to accede to Pakistan in 1948. The current province of Balochistan was formed in 1970. Since then, an insurgency has periodically flared up over demands for greater autonomy for the region and a larger share of the natural resources.

joint statement issued by prime ministers Manmohan Singh and Yousuf Raza Gilani specifically referred to the need to address "threats in Balochistan", an oblique allusion to Pakistani allegations of Indian intelligence involvement in destabilising the region.

Till a couple of decades ago, Quetta was a sleepy little town known for its dried fruit markets hawking excellent pistas, almonds, apricots and pine nuts brought in from neighbouring Iran and Afghanistan, as well as its clean air. Post the massive influx in the 1980s of Afghan refugees—many of whom have settled in the city and

established businesses—Quetta lost its reputation as a 'clean', well-manicured town. And recently, it has also received notoriety after American and Afghan allegations—denied strongly by Pakistan—that the top leadership of the Taliban is based in the city.

Quetta is now part of a completely different, deadly political battle raging across the province, which has seen bombs go off with alarming regularity, electricity pylons and infrastructure assets destroyed, security personnel attacked by shadowy insurgents, disappearances of people and a rising tide of political radicalism. As a military

operation against "terrorists" rages in Kohlu and Dera Bugti districts, over 150 miles to the south-east, Quetta has seen a number of targeted killings of policemen and non-Baloch residents in an apparent effort at ethnic cleansing.

Driving into the city from the airport, the presence of paramilitary forces is evident. Their trucks with machine guns mounted on top can often be seen patrolling on the roads while sandbagged bunkers have been established at various intersections. Further in are a number of checkpoints, a nuisance that residents complain bitterly about, as well as recounting tales of the